

CAUSE AND EFFECT

Balance of TERROR

The rage of the Kondhs is like a bushfire: easy to ignite, difficult to extinguish. In Orissa's Kandhamal district, a cocktail of socio-economic imbalances and unchecked conversion now threatens to consume the Naveen Patnaik Government even as ethnic and communal strife helps Maoists spread their influence. The re-conversion campaign amid continuing anti-Pana, anti-Christian violence in Kandhamal and the Maoist threat has pushed Orissa to the brink.

While Patnaik and his BJD were busy organising a peace march, the ABVP held a dharna that talked of 'Christian terrorism'. The present turmoil is the outcome of divides at many levels—social, ethnic and religious. The Kondhs and Panas have been daggers drawn for long, but the tension of late was fuelled by the killing of VHP leader Swami Lakshmanananda. More than three-fourths of Kondhs are Hindus while 80 per cent of Panas are Christian converts. Traditionally, Panas, a Scheduled Caste, were treated by Kondhs as 'untouchables'. The British used the Panas to collect revenue from Kondh subjects. As most had converted, they were favoured by the British. Despite being a mi-

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THE FEAR PERSISTS:
A relief camp

nority—19 per cent against 52 per cent Kondhs—they rose in status.

If the nearly 1,200 churches and 400 Christian institutions have for long been an eyesore for Hindutava forces, it is conversion that helped the Sangh Parivar grow in Orissa and helped the BJP capture power in alliance with the BJD. Kandhamal's decadal census figures confirm what RSS-VHP had feared: the 'abnormal' increase of the Christian population. It was 75,579 in 1991 and rose to 1,17,954 a decade later.

Bhubaneswar Diocese Vicar General Fr Joseph Kalathil sees the business community, of which the district has a sizeable population, behind the campaign. In the past 60 years they migrated from the coastal region, established businesses and took the leadership of the anti-Church movement. Since 1988, there have been periodic clashes and some Pana youth set up their own militias. Some moved to the People's Liberation Guerrilla Army, the military wing of the Maoists in Christian-dominated areas. The recent violence is therefore seen as an attempt by the majority to bring about a balance of terror.

by Farzand Ahmed

now the leader of NCP in the state, "his incompetency is the mother of the Kandhamal crisis". According to a disillusioned Biju Janata Dal (BJD) leader, "he still looks great because of his distance from the people". And he looks great on the drawing room walls of the disgruntled as well.

The disgruntled are many, and in the beginning, all of them perhaps wanted to be his surrogate fathers. He has done to them what Mrs G had done to the Syndicate. The demolition of the old guard was a necessary condition for the declaration of his political adulthood. He is not one of them. He has never been. Well, he doesn't even speak their language. He is not a people's

ACTION HERO

"In nine months hostels were built for one lakh girls. I am firm in my belief that matters will improve."

"Thousands have been arrested and there is no pressure from BJP at all."

prince; he doesn't make himself all that comprehensible—or accessible—to his subjects. That is why he has a kind of political freshness about him even after eight years in power. The enigma has not worn off. He, once a professional socialite in New York, has become the unlikely leader to challenge politics-as-usual. Ever thought you were in the wrong profession, you ask him. "I'm lucky to be in this profession." Luckily for Orissa, Naveen Patnaik is not yet your average professional politician.

with Farzand Ahmed